

Europe braces as Trump heads to NATO

His grievances over the Iran war help cast a pall over this year’s summit, in Turkey.

By MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — The leaders of Europe are bracing for another turbulent summit with President Trump this week as NATO members gather for their annual meeting in the Turkish capital.

European diplomats view Trump’s decision to attend as a positive sign of his continued commitment to the alliance. But the president’s grievances with several European governments over their refusal to join the U.S. war with Iran have cast a pall over a summit already strained by Trump’s wavering support for the continent.

The secretary-general of the transatlantic alliance, Mark Rutte, told reporters Monday that Trump had aired his resentments in a recent phone call. But Rutte countered with a mix of flattery and countervailing facts that has thus far kept Trump engaged.

Although Trump has accused European leaders of denying U.S. forces access to allied bases for takeoffs and refueling during the war, Rutte noted that about 5,000 sorties supporting Operation Epic Fury launched from European airfields. And last Friday, France and Britain committed to a joint military mission with Oman to support freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz — “an extremely important development,” Rutte said.

At last year’s summit, held in The Hague, all member states of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization — with the exception of Spain — agreed to spend 5% of their GDP on defense by 2035, marking a significant increase in historic spending goals for modern Europe. The pledge is divided into two categories, with 3.5% of spending allocated to core military requirements, and the rest committed to a broad set of security-related

[See NATO, A5]



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

HOMES, top, are under construction in Santa Clarita, now L.A. County’s third largest city. Above, downtown L.A. is also attracting more new residents.

L.A. County’s unexpected boomtowns

Northern areas are seeing big population gains

By Terry Castleman

When residents and business owners began talking about creating a city in the Santa Clarita Valley nearly three decades ago, few could have imagined the demographic juggernaut the region would become.

Back then, it was a far-flung collection of four distinct communities: The very suburban Valencia, the historic towns of Saugus and Newhall and the more rural Canyon Country.

Developers knew the valley 45 miles north of downtown Los Angeles was ripe for subdivisions and office parks. But Santa Clarita’s growth has been so dramatic that it now ranks as the third largest city in Los Angeles County behind L.A. and Long Beach.

Santa Clarita’s growth is all the more remarkable given the sluggish population expansion in other parts of Los Angeles County in the last few years. Data show L.A. County as a whole grew by 0.5% from 2010 to 2024, to 9.81 million from 9.76 million.

Growth has often been stymied by a shortage of vacant land on which to build new housing.

Santa Clarita, meanwhile, has been L.A. County’s growth champion of the last 25 years, according to a Times analysis of U.S. census data.

It is followed by the Antelope Valley, another exurb known for inexpensive tract housing — if you can deal with the commute.

The data have identified some other unexpected boomtowns, as well.

Years of high-rise residential development in downtown Los Angeles have made it a big winner within the city of Los Angeles.

Behind downtown is Chinatown, another old-line neighborhood that has experienced a major expansion of lower-rise residential apartments and condos.

But L.A.’s biggest growth area, Playa Vista, is actually miles to the west in a com-

[See Boomtowns, A7]

Uproar follows Trump’s call on FIFA red card

President has history of phoning officials, applying pressure to get what he wants.

By ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — President Trump did not like what he saw. So, once again, he picked up the phone.

Trump said Monday that he called FIFA President Gianni Infantino after he disagreed with the World Cup referee who gave a red card to U.S. men’s soccer team star Folarin Balogun. The discipline, which Trump called “very unfair” and a “stain” on the World Cup, would have barred Balogun from playing in Monday’s elimination game against Belgium.

“I asked for a review because I didn’t think it was a foul,” Trump told reporters during an event in the Oval Office. “I am good at this stuff. I didn’t think it was a foul. I thought it was two great athletes that crashed into each other and got entangled.”

Trump said he initially didn’t know “what the hell a red card was” or what it

U.S. vies for berth in quarterfinals

For coverage of Monday’s game against Belgium, visit our e-newspaper or go to latimes.com/sports.

meant. “When I found out, I said, ‘You gotta be kidding!’”

Trump’s involvement in soccer’s disciplinary process created an international uproar.

UEFA, European soccer’s governing body, said FIFA “crossed a red line” with the reversal. Belgium’s football association appealed the ruling, which FIFA denied during a hearing Monday. Belgian coach Rudi Garcia mocked the decision as an April Fools’ joke.

“This decision clearly raises many questions,” Belgian Foreign Minister Maxime Prevot said in a statement Monday, according to the New York Times.

“If a phone call really is what explains this incomprehensible decision, it would amount to undermining the most basic rules of soccer and sports,” added Prevot, a former soccer ref- [See Red card, A5]

Social media cited in Newport melee

Local police trying to figure out why throngs converged July 4, leading to 402 arrests.

By HANNAH FRY AND RICHARD WINTON

Newport Beach police are used to crowds on the Fourth of July.

But they were not expecting the thousands of teenagers and young adults who descended on the city Saturday, leading to hours of chaos and vandalism that some say is the worst the city has seen in years.

Authorities are still trying to determine what drew so many people. The Newport Beach Police Assn. blamed a viral “TikTok takeover” on social media that attracted crowds. It’s still unclear whether a single

post was the draw or how it was organized, and police said the investigation is ongoing.

Newport Beach police routinely monitor social media, but saw no early indication that such massive crowds would be arriving on the Peninsula.

And that may have been by design. According to some law enforcement experts, it’s becoming increasingly difficult to find such posts in a world of private chat groups and apps.

People are increasingly planning meetups on Signal, WhatsApp and Discord, which aren’t publicly viewable, said Mike Parker, a retired Los Angeles County Sheriff’s Department commander.

“Monitoring takes time and cops have to find ways to become members and that is very hard,” he said. “So [See Fourth of July, A7]

COLUMN ONE

A cancer survivor’s 100-mile journey of hope

In the predawn chill of the Sierra Nevada, Christina Klayko bounced on the balls of her feet, trying to keep warm and calm before one of the planet’s most punishing competitions.

Surrounding her at the starting line for the Western States Endurance Run — a lung-busting 100-mile race over towering mountain ridges and through deep, sun-scorched canyons — were some of the most elite athletes in the world, including former champions, record holders and an Olympic marathon medalist.

Klayko, a 48-year-old mother of three, had no illusions about winning — she was just relieved to be there. She is a two-time cancer survivor, and a year earlier, she was lying on an operating table enduring a full hysterectomy, followed

A race through the Sierra is agony — and life-affirming

By Jack Dolan

REPORTING FROM OLYMPIC VALLEY, CALIF.



WILLIAM HALE IRWIN For The Times

CHRISTINA KLAYKO struggles to reach the finish line in the Western States Endurance Run.

by months of radiation treatment. She was terrified she might die.

“I was in a very dark place,” she said. “I would have given anything just to be able to walk my dog around the block.”

But Klayko, a former software engineer from Los Altos, Calif., has never been a quitter. In her 20s, after a breast cancer diagnosis and a full mastectomy, she finished an Ironman triathlon. On the last Saturday of June, she was hoping to complete an even more miraculous comeback.

To do so, she would have to run almost half the width of California, from the shores of Lake Tahoe to Auburn, a former mining town in the foothills above Sacramento, along remote, rock-strewn paths that rise and fall like a roller coaster.

In all, she would have to [See Endurance, A6]



GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

HIKERS pass a “wind phone” on Mt. Rubidoux last year that is dedicated to a woman who killed herself.

‘Wind phones’ offer a lifeline to the bereaved

By GINA FERAZZI

It was a hot and dry summer night in 2019 when the Campbell family drove from Los Angeles to their new desert vacation home in Joshua Tree.

As they crested a hill on Highway 62, a drunk driver crashed into their car.

Ruby, 17, and Hart, 14, were killed.

To channel their grief, their parents — like thousands of people across the globe — created a “wind phone.”

Sitting on a patch of desert sand, the wind phone created by Colin Campbell and Gail Lerner consists of a wooden box sitting atop a cabinet with a chair nearby. Inside the box is an old rotary telephone. There are no wires. But those who want to can pick up the receiver to say out loud the emotions they’ve bottled inside — a chance to reflect, reminisce and, in a way, connect.

The first wind phone was created in 2010 by Japanese garden designer Itaru Sasaki after the loss of his [See Phones, A8]

New satellites to monitor wildfires

FireSat, manufactured in San José, will help incident commanders in California and beyond. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Struggling Xbox to cut 3,200 jobs

CEO plans a sweeping reorganization as she faces an increasingly challenging gaming landscape. **BUSINESS, A9**

Here’s who will get Emmy nods

Awards columnist Glenn Whipp makes his final predictions. Welcome to “Widow’s Bay.” **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather
Partly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 84/63. **B6**

